AI washing as a knowledge governance failure in organizations

Yunjie Wang and Wei Zhang

Abstract

Purpose – *Growing evidence suggests that firms increasingly overstate their artificial intelligence (AI) adoption in corporate communications, yet the organizational consequences of AI washing remain underexplored. This study aims to conceptualize AI washing as a knowledge governance failure (KGF) and develops a framework explaining how persistent symbolic AI adoption progressively undermines organizational learning, knowledge validation and capability development.*

Design/methodology/approach – *Drawing on the knowledge-based view (KBV) and knowledge governance theory (KGT), this conceptual study develops an integrative framework. An illustrative multiple-case analysis of manufacturing settings is used to demonstrate the proposed governance mechanisms and the evolutionary trajectory of AI washing.*

Findings – *AI washing is conceptualized as a sequential KGF process driven by legitimacy pressures. Persistent symbolic AI adoption redirects managerial attention away from substantive capability development, leading to resource misallocation, cognitive decoupling, cognitive debt accumulation, evaluation failure, knowledge validation erosion, and ultimately organizational brain rot. These mechanisms reinforce one another through a self-reinforcing governance deterioration cycle.*

Practical implications – *Organizations should address AI washing as a knowledge governance challenge rather than merely a disclosure issue. Aligning AI adoption with organizational learning, knowledge validation and governance mechanisms is essential for sustaining AI-enabled capability development.*

Originality/value – *This study extends AI washing research beyond disclosure and legitimacy perspectives by conceptualizing it as a dynamic knowledge governance process. By integrating KBV and KGT, it explains how symbolic AI adoption progressively erodes organizational knowledge systems and provides a theoretical foundation for future empirical research on AI governance.*

Keywords *AI washing, Knowledge governance, Knowledge management, Strategic decoupling, Organizational brain rot*

Paper type *Viewpoint*

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1. Introduction

A sharp increase has been seen in the use of artificial intelligence (AI)-related terminology in corporate learning, knowledge sharing and strategic communications in the annual reports of global companies (Ca' Zorzi *et al.*, 2025). The application of AI has undoubtedly become a prominent feature of organizational knowledge management (KM) practice. Although a significant number of companies have portrayed the adoption of AI as a marker of knowledge creation for innovation (Shi *et al.*, 2025), organizations regularly encounter uneven levels of implementation and operational integration between AI terms and KM processes (McKinsey and Company, 2024). For example, when companies are faced with institutional and competitive pressures, they may prioritize symbolic alignment with AI technologies over substantive investments in organizational learning and capability development (Bennich, 2024). According to recent enforcement actions by the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) involving Delphia, Global Predictions and Presto (SEC, 2024, 2025), there are growing concerns regarding the exaggeration of

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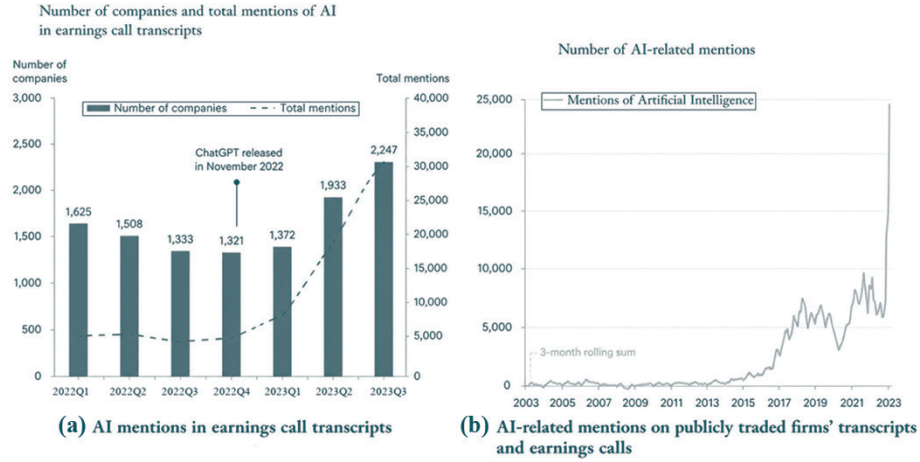
AI-related claims in public. As can be seen in Figure 1(a) and (b), a growing number of companies have reported their usage of AI technologies in the transcripts of corporate earnings calls, and AI mentions have become a valuable strategic signal for companies to cater to their stakeholders. However, AI-related discourse and symbolic AI positioning are often not accompanied by actual investments in digital infrastructure or capability development (Mhaske *et al.*, 2025). In some cases, these observations imply that public AI claims far transcend the current technological capabilities of companies and their operational readiness.

This kind of crucial strategic decoupling demonstrates that firms may adopt AI symbolically without investing sufficiently in learning AI knowledge or building the capabilities to leverage AI. Therefore, there is a paradox between external corporate reporting and substantive AI capability development. When such strategic decoupling widens, organizations may experience increasing governance tensions regarding the ways in which technological knowledge is evaluated, validated, and integrated into organizational practice (Branda, 2026; Meyer and Rowan, 1977). Due to the lack of sophisticated AI knowledge, AI adoption without corresponding investments in AI-related capability development often results in knowledge governance (KG) tensions. However, despite the increasing concerns relating to the aforementioned KG problems, limited research has attempted to solve the overly inflating claims regarding the use of AI by firms.

To fill this gap, this article departs from an integrative KM perspective that consists of the knowledge-based view (KBV) and knowledge governance theory (KGT). Referring to the logic of greenwashing (Delmas and Burbano, 2011), AI washing is conceptualized as an organizational manifestation of knowledge governance failure (KGF) that results from persistent symbolic AI adoption and causes strategic decoupling. It is further argued that the notion of AI washing refers to an organizational condition whereby symbolic AI positioning becomes increasingly disconnected from substantive organizational learning and KG capacity.

This article contributes to KM literature in numerous ways. First, grounded in the synthesis of the KBV and KGT, it proposes the notion of AI washing as a means of conceptualizing a

Figure 1 Increasing prevalence of AI-related disclosures in corporate communications



(a) AI mentions in earnings call transcripts

(b) AI-related mentions on publicly traded firms' transcripts and earnings calls

Note: Panel (a) reports the number of companies and total AI mentions in earnings call transcripts from 2022Q1 to 2023Q3. Panel (b) shows the trend of AI-related mentions in publicly traded companies' transcripts and earnings calls.
Source: Accenture Technology Vision 2024; Bloomberg (2023)

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nascent and insufficiently theorized phenomenon of symbolic AI adoption in organizations. Second, it expands upon previous discussions relating to the act of overly inflating AI usage by addressing how persistent symbolic AI adoption gradually weakens organizational learning, distorts managerial attention, and reduces the capacity of an organization to validate and integrate reliable knowledge. In practical terms, it highlights that managers who face strong legitimacy and competitive pressures may become vulnerable to symbolic AI adoption due to the underdevelopment of substantive AI understanding and governance mechanisms. Therefore, this paper encourages executive leaders to strengthen AI literacy, organizational learning and KG processes so that AI adoption continues to be aligned with substantive organizational capability development, knowledge verification and organizational learning, rather than symbolic technological positioning.

2. Theoretical foundation

2.1 Distinguishing artificial intelligence washing from artificial intelligence misuse and shadow artificial intelligence usage

In addition to the rapid diffusion of AI across industries, an ever-increasing set of concepts has emerged to describe problematic AI adoption, implementation and governance patterns. As several of these concepts are related to inappropriate or suboptimal AI use, clarifying its conceptual boundaries is imperative. More specifically, this study distinguishes AI washing from related concepts based on three dimensions: level of analysis, intentionality and governance consequences.

AI washing refers to symbolic AI adoption that is driven by external legitimacy expectations without corresponding substantive capability development, knowledge verification, or operational integration in this study. AI washing describes an organizational condition where symbolic technological positioning progressively becomes disconnected from substantive organizational learning and KG, rather than representing isolated misleading claims (Song *et al.*, 2026). In the proposed framework, AI washing constitutes the focal governance phenomenon, while strategic decoupling, cognitive decoupling, cognitive debt, evaluation failure, knowledge validation erosion and organizational brain rot represent subsequent structural conditions, governance mechanisms or organizational outcomes that arise from persistent symbolic AI adoption.

AI washing is conceptually distinct from AI misuse. AI misuse was defined by Trotsyuk *et al.* (2024) as the deliberate use of AI technologies with the intent to cause harm or engage in unethical activities. The defining characteristic of AI misuse is intentional harmful or unethical deployment. Conversely, malicious intent is not required with AI washing, and it emerges when organizations respond to legitimacy, competitive or investor pressures through the emphasis of symbolic AI capability while also underinvesting in substantive capability development (Bennich, 2024). As a consequence, AI washing represents a governance problem that is associated with legitimacy-driven organizational adaptation, rather than intentional technological abuse. Although AI washing and AI misuse may generate organizational risks, they are fundamentally different in terms of primary intentionality, level of analysis, and governance consequences. Unlike AI misuse, AI washing conceptualizes organizational risk as a process where legitimacy-driven symbolic AI adoption results in a progressive level of KGF.

AI washing is also conceptually distinct from shadow AI usage. Shadow AI usage was defined by Chin *et al.* (2025) as the unauthorized use of AI tools by employees who are outside of formal organizational governance. Shadow AI primarily concerns operational behavior that occurs at the individual or team level, which is often motivated by efficiency improvement and not organizational signaling. At the same time, AI washing operates at the organizational level, where symbolic AI positioning is encouraged by external legitimacy pressures, despite insufficient organizational capability development (Sun *et al.*, 2026).

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While shadow AI may be a contributing factor to governance risks, AI washing concerns the broader organizational prioritization of symbolic legitimacy over substantive knowledge development. Therefore, the two concepts differ in terms of organizational level, authorization context, triggering mechanisms and governance objectives. However, the extensive normalization of shadow AI practices may occasionally serve to reinforce AI washing narratives. While shadow AI usage primarily concerns unauthorized employee behavior, AI washing is focused on governance consequences that emerge at the organizational level through the persistent adoption of symbolic AI.

These distinctions are important as AI washing differs from AI misuse and shadow AI usage in its organizational level and underlying intentionality, in addition to its emphasis on governance consequences. AI washing explains how persistent symbolic AI adoption progressively leads to KGF, rather than focusing on unethical AI use or unauthorized employee behavior. It represents a specific organizational governance condition that is characterized by persistent symbolic AI adoption under external legitimacy pressures. Expanding upon the work of Guglyuvatyy (2026), the opacity and complexity of AI systems may reduce organizational transparency and weaken knowledge verification processes. This creates conditions where symbolic AI positioning becomes progressively disconnected from substantive capability development. From a KM and KG perspective, AI washing is conceptualized as an organizational manifestation of KGF, whereby organizational learning, knowledge validation and capability development are progressively undermined by legitimacy-driven symbolic AI adoption over time (Gelashvili-Luik *et al.*, 2025).

2.2 Synthesizing knowledge-based view and knowledge governance theory to build theoretical underpinning for AI washing

In combination, KBV and KGT provide a complementary theoretical foundation that can explain how legitimacy-driven symbolic AI adoption can weaken KG processes. It can then ultimately undermine organizational learning and knowledge capability development (Branda, 2026). More specifically, KBV explains why organizational knowledge resources and capability development constitute the strategic foundation of firms. At the same time, KGT explains how symbolic AI adoption progressively weakens the governance mechanisms that are required for validating, integrating and preserving those knowledge resources.

From KBV, organizational competitiveness is dependent on access to knowledge and the ability of a company to develop, retain, validate, integrate and operationalize knowledge effectively (Grant, 1996). Therefore, organizational learning and capability development are dependent on the continuous accumulation, transfer and application of explicit and tacit knowledge resources (Nonaka, 1994). However, AI washing can potentially weaken these processes by encouraging symbolic representations of technological capability that are not supported by corresponding organizational learning or knowledge infrastructure (Chin *et al.*, 2024; Elhajjar and Itani, 2025). Such symbolic AI adoption may contribute to cognitive decoupling over time, where managerial assumptions relating to AI capability become increasingly disconnected from operational realities and internal knowledge capacity (Sun *et al.*, 2026).

These conditions may reduce the capacity of an organization to develop, retain and operationalize reliable knowledge resources, which can weaken long-term organizational learning and cognitive resilience (Gerlach and Lange, 2026). However, KBV alone cannot explain how organizations progressively fail to govern these knowledge resources under symbolic AI adoption conditions.

KGT explains how the validation, integration, monitoring and effective use of knowledge resources are shaped by organizational governance mechanisms (Foss, 2007; Shi *et al.*, 2025). Managerial attention may increasingly shift toward symbolic AI signaling, rather than substantive capability development (Ocasio, 1997). This could potentially gradually weaken

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governance mechanisms that are responsible for the evaluation, validation, integration and oversight of technological knowledge. As a consequence, organizations may increasingly prioritize external AI signaling over substantive capability development. This can allow AI-generated outputs to circulate and become embedded in organizational routines without sufficient validation or scrutiny (Nelson and Winter, 2004). Employees and decision-makers may also become increasingly cognitively detached from the underlying operational and data limitations of these systems. When organizations lack mechanisms that are capable of evaluating AI-generated insights before operational integration, these governance risks become particularly significant (Guillen-Aguinaga *et al.*, 2025).

2.3 Conceptualizing artificial intelligence washing as knowledge governance failure

Expanding upon the complementary insights of the KBV and KGT, this study conceptualizes AI washing as an organizational manifestation of KGF that emerges due to persistent symbolic AI adoption under external legitimacy pressures. AI washing describes an organizational condition where symbolic AI positioning becomes progressively disconnected from substantive capability development, knowledge verification and organizational learning, rather than representing isolated symbolic AI claims or deceptive communication. As is presented in Table 1, AI washing-related symbolic AI adoption differs from substantive AI capability development across several dimensions, which include managerial attention allocation, knowledge verification, governance oversight and organizational learning processes (Chin *et al.*, 2025).

Persistent cognitive decoupling may reduce the capacity of an organization to critically evaluate technological knowledge, which increases reliance on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge. As lower-quality knowledge becomes progressively embedded in organizational routines and decision-making processes (Nelson and Winter, 2004), organizations may gradually lose their ability to identify capability gaps, critically assess technological knowledge, and correct ineffective technological practices. This further weakens the necessary governance processes for validating, integrating and operationalizing reliable technological knowledge. Therefore, organizations lose their ability to develop, retain and operationalize reliable knowledge resources, which ultimately weakens long-term capability development (Gerlach and Lange, 2026). This erosion is particularly problematic as substantive AI capability development is dependent on the continued orchestration of organizational knowledge resources and capability reconfiguration, and not symbolic AI positioning alone (Chin *et al.*, 2025). When companies prioritize symbolic AI narratives over sustained capability development, the gap between symbolic AI adoption and substantive capability development can increase (Silveira and De Paula, 2026).

Table 1 Distinctions between symbolic AI adoption and substantive AI capability development

Dimension	*AI Washing-Related symbolic AI adoption*	*Substantive AI development*
Knowledge base	Symbolically framed and weakly integrated into internal knowledge systems	Substantive, validated, internally integrated
Capability claims	Symbolically framed or weakly substantiated	Evidence-based and transparent
Investment pattern	Limited or symbolically oriented	Sustained investment in R&D and training
Managerial attention	Oriented toward legitimacy signaling and symbolic AI positioning	Oriented toward organizational learning and capability development
Governance	Weak knowledge verification and governance oversight	Strong KG and auditing
Learning process	Fragmented, superficial, or weakly institutionalized	Continuous and cumulative
Outcomes	Capability gaps, weakly validated knowledge outputs, and weakened organizational learning	Capability development and performance gains

Source(s): Authors' own work

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Therefore, AI washing can be understood as being an organizational manifestation of KGF whereby legitimacy-driven symbolic AI adoption progressively weakens the governance mechanisms that are required for validating, integrating and operationalizing organizational knowledge. This reduces the capacity of a company to develop, retain and leverage reliable knowledge resources.

3. Methodology

3.1 Methods

An illustrative case study refers to the use of a descriptive study that depicts one or more circumstances of an event to distill patterns for elucidating a particular phenomenon (Siggelkow, 2007). Illustrative case development in conceptual research is to provide a realistic organizational narrative that connects theoretical constructs with practical organizational processes (Yin, 2018). Rather than examining an individual firm's historical experience, the narrative serves as an analytical device that demonstrates the causal relationships proposed conceptually. An illustrative case is not intended to support statistical generalization or establish causal mechanisms empirically. Instead, it serves to enhance conceptual clarity by translating abstract notions into a realistic organizational context. As such, an illustrative case study methodology is especially suitable for making sense of a nascent, under-researched phenomenon like AI washing.

Following the above logic, this study thus adopts an illustrative case study methodology to demonstrate how AI washing results in organizational KGF in practice. Given the scarcity of empirical evidence, our illustrative case was constructed through a narrative synthesis of published sources, including the literature on AI-related organizational learning, KM and capability development, together with industry reports and regulatory investigations documenting challenges associated with enterprise AI application. Following the principles of case study research (Eisenhardt and Graebner, 2007), particular attention was given to recurring themes reported across these sources. Considering the aim of this article, we placed particular emphasis on the various effects of firms' AI adoption without corresponding capability development. These recurring patterns were integrated into a single, internally consistent scenario representing a plausible trajectory of AI washing in organizations.

3.2 Multiple cases of Chinese manufacturing firms

Drawing on the illustrative case methodology, this study develops a multiple-case narrative of AI washing in the context of traditional manufacturing firms in China. This setting is theoretically relevant because Chinese manufacturers are undergoing rapid digital transformation under intensifying competitive pressures, while national policies actively promote AI adoption, smart factory development, and industrial digital platforms. For example, leading manufacturers such as Midea Group and Haier Group have advanced AI-enabled factories and industrial internet platforms as central components of their intelligent manufacturing strategies. Against this backdrop, the research team developed three illustrative cases of Chinese original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) based on recurring patterns identified in the academic literature, industry reports, and documented manufacturing transformation practices. Rather than representing specific firms, these cases synthesize common organizational dynamics reported across multiple sources, providing analytically comparable scenarios that illustrate how AI washing may emerge and evolve in traditional manufacturing settings.

3.2.1 Case 1: Symbolic artificial intelligence adoption and capability misalignment. Firm A is an illustrative garment OEM located in Guangdong Province, China. In response to intensifying market competition and increasing institutional expectations for digital transformation, senior management announced an AI transformation strategy in 2024. The firm introduced AI-enabled production monitoring systems, automated quality inspection

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technologies, and collaborative projects with external technology providers. These initiatives received considerable attention in corporate communications and were promoted as evidence of successful digital upgrading.

Despite these visible investments, the firm's AI deployment outpaced the development of the organizational capabilities necessary to support effective implementation. Managerial attention and financial resources were primarily directed toward technology acquisition and the external communication of AI initiatives, while comparatively limited investment was made in employee AI training, data governance, workflow redesign and mechanisms for integrating AI-generated insights with existing engineering and operational knowledge. Although advanced AI systems were deployed, employees lacked the knowledge and routines required to interpret AI outputs, evaluate their reliability, and incorporate them into day-to-day manufacturing decisions.

3.2.2 Case 2: Artificial intelligence dependence and organizational learning erosion. Firm B is an electronics OEM operating in a highly competitive environment characterized by increasing customer expectations for product quality and digital supply chain integration. To enhance operational efficiency, the firm introduces AI-based decision-support systems and encourages employees to incorporate AI-generated recommendations into routine production and operational decision-making. These initiatives are presented as evidence of the firm's commitment to intelligent manufacturing and digital transformation.

As AI applications become increasingly embedded in organizational processes, however, managerial attention gradually shifts from developing organizational knowledge toward greater reliance on technological solutions. Employees increasingly accept AI-generated recommendations with limited critical evaluation, while experienced engineers become less involved in diagnosing production problems and mentoring less experienced employees. At the same time, comparatively little investment is directed toward knowledge-sharing mechanisms, cross-functional learning, or processes that integrate AI-generated insights with accumulated manufacturing expertise.

Consequently, increasing dependence on AI-generated information reduces opportunities for experiential learning, tacit knowledge transfer, and collective problem-solving. Over time, organizational learning becomes increasingly technology-dependent rather than knowledge-driven, weakening the firm's ability to develop and renew its internal capabilities.

3.2.3 Case 3: Knowledge governance failure and capability erosion. Firm C is an auto parts OEM in China that invests extensively in smart factory initiatives, including industrial data platforms, automated production systems, and AI-based optimization tools. Responding to competitive pressures and institutional expectations for digital transformation, senior managers promote these initiatives as evidence of successful AI adoption and highlight the firm's intelligent manufacturing capabilities in communications with external stakeholders.

Despite these substantial technological investments, the organization fails to establish governance mechanisms necessary for the effective creation, validation and utilization of AI-generated knowledge. Limited attention is devoted to data quality governance, accountability for AI-supported decision-making, expert review procedures, and mechanisms for integrating AI-generated insights with existing manufacturing knowledge. Although AI systems continuously generate large volumes of operational information, employees and managers lack standardized processes to assess the reliability, contextual relevance and practical applicability of AI outputs before incorporating them into operational decisions.

Over time, insufficiently validated AI-generated knowledge becomes embedded in organizational routines, while the firm's capacity to detect technological limitations, challenge erroneous recommendations, and refine organizational practices progressively weakens. Consequently, knowledge quality deteriorates, organizational learning becomes

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increasingly constrained, and AI-enabled capability development stagnates despite continued investment in advanced technologies.

4. Case analysis/results

In summary, Case 1 illustrates how AI washing may initially emerge under institutional pressures and competitive imitation, as organizations emphasize the visible adoption of AI technologies while underinvesting in the knowledge development, organizational learning and governance mechanisms required to realize substantive AI-enabled transformation. Consequently, symbolic AI adoption creates a growing gap between technological visibility and organizational capability, laying the foundation for subsequent knowledge governance challenges. Case 2 illustrates how AI washing may evolve beyond symbolic adoption to reshape organizational learning processes when visible AI implementation is prioritized over the continued development of human expertise, knowledge integration and organizational learning capabilities. Case 3 illustrates the culmination of AI washing, whereby symbolic AI adoption gradually develops into a broader knowledge governance failure. Rather than merely overstating technological capabilities, organizations fail to establish the governance mechanisms required to validate, integrate and leverage AI-generated knowledge, thereby undermining sustained organizational learning, knowledge accumulation, and long-term capability development.

Taken together, the analysis above further suggests that strategic decoupling may emerge during symbolic AI adoption, as organizations prioritize the external visibility of AI implementation over the internal development of AI-enabled capabilities. Under these conditions, cognitive debt accumulates as weakly validated AI-generated knowledge becomes embedded in organizational routines and decision-making processes. Over time, this accumulation progressively erodes organizational learning, knowledge integration and critical judgment, ultimately contributing to organizational brain rot.

For a more comprehensive understanding, Figure 2 and Table 2 are drawn to show how and why AI washing can be viewed as a *sequential knowledge governance failure (KGF)* process rather than a collection of independent organizational mechanisms. A detailed explanation is as follows.

4.1 Resource misallocation, cognitive decoupling and cognitive debt accumulation

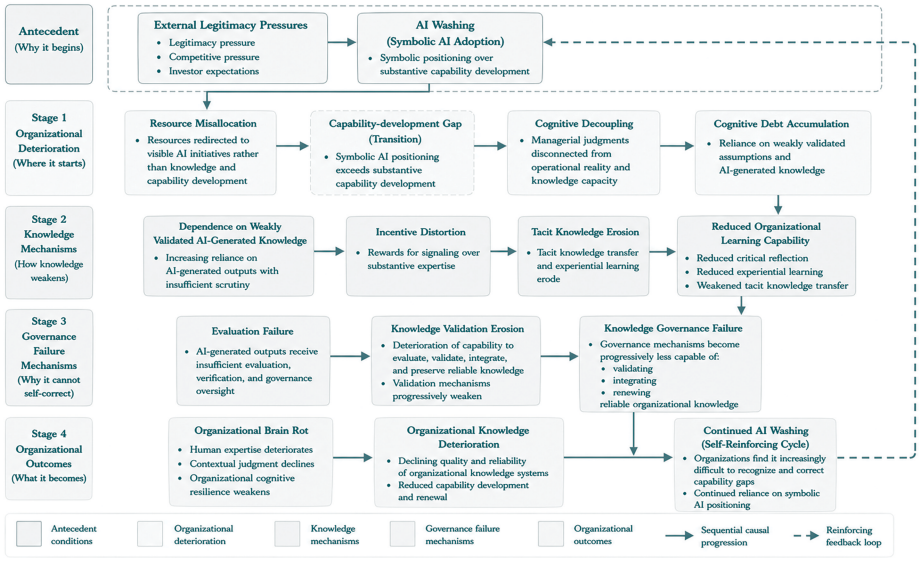
AI washing may contribute to organizational resource misallocation by redirecting managerial attention and organizational investment away from substantive knowledge development toward symbolic demonstrations of AI capability (Elsayed, 2026; Nakash and Bolisani, 2025). Under external legitimacy and competitive pressures, organizations may prioritize symbolic AI positioning over sustained investments in employee learning, knowledge verification and capability development. Consequently, organizational resources become concentrated on externally visible AI initiatives rather than on the internal processes required to develop, validate and integrate reliable technological knowledge (March, 1991).

As these resource allocation patterns persist, organizations may experience a growing gap between symbolic AI positioning and substantive capability development (Bennich, 2024). Although AI capability is increasingly emphasized in external communications, comparatively limited investment is directed toward organizational learning, knowledge infrastructure, and employees' ability to critically evaluate AI-generated knowledge. This capability-development gap creates the conditions under which managerial perceptions of AI capability become detached from the organization's actual operational and knowledge capacity.

Such conditions may contribute to cognitive decoupling, whereby managerial assumptions regarding AI capability become disconnected from operational realities, internal knowledge capacity and substantive learning processes. As managerial judgments become based on

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Figure 2 Sequential knowledge governance failure process associated with AI washing



Note: The figure illustrates how external legitimacy pressures initiate AI washing, which progressively contributes to resource misallocation, cognitive decoupling, cognitive debt accumulation, dependence on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge, incentive distortion, tacit knowledge erosion, evaluation failure, knowledge validation erosion, knowledge governance failure, organizational brain rot, and ultimately organizational knowledge deterioration. The dashed arrows indicate the self-reinforcing feedback loop through which organizational knowledge deterioration reinforces continued AI washing over time
Source: Authors' own work

perceived technological sophistication rather than validated organizational knowledge, organizations may gradually lose the capacity to critically evaluate technological knowledge, identify capability limitations, and recognize ineffective technological practices.

Persistent cognitive decoupling may subsequently contribute to cognitive debt accumulation, referring to growing reliance on weakly validated assumptions, shallow technological understanding, and insufficiently scrutinized AI-generated knowledge in organizational decision-making (Storey, 2026; Tian and Zhang, 2025). As weakly validated assumptions become embedded within organizational routines and operational processes (Nelson and Winter, 2004), organizations may become increasingly dependent on AI-generated knowledge that has not been adequately evaluated or verified, making it more difficult to distinguish symbolic AI capability claims from substantive technological competence (Figure 2).

Resource misallocation, the capability-development gap, and cognitive decoupling represent successive organizational mechanisms contributing to cognitive debt accumulation (Figure 2). Each stage creates the conditions necessary for the emergence of the next. Cognitive debt ultimately produces a weakly validated organizational knowledge base that provides the foundation for the subsequent knowledge and governance mechanisms discussed in the following section.

4.2 Incentive distortion and tacit knowledge erosion

As cognitive debt accumulates, organizations may become increasingly dependent on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge. AI washing may further distort organizational incentive structures by rewarding symbolic demonstrations of AI capability rather than deep

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Table 2 Sequential KGF process associated with AI washing

Mechanism	*Trigger*	*Organizational process*	*Governance failure*	*KG consequence*
AI washing	External legitimacy, competitive, and investor pressures	Symbolic AI positioning is prioritized over substantive AI capability development	Governance attention shifts from knowledge quality toward legitimacy signaling	Resource misallocation
Resource misallocation	Persistent symbolic AI adoption	Resources are redirected away from learning, knowledge verification, and capability development	Reduced investment in knowledge verification and capability building	Cognitive decoupling
Cognitive decoupling	Capability-development gap	Managerial judgments become detached from operational reality and organizational knowledge	Weakened evaluation of AI-generated knowledge	Cognitive debt accumulation
Cognitive debt accumulation	Persistent cognitive decoupling	Organizations increasingly depend on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge	Weak assumptions become embedded within organizational routines	Evaluation failure
Evaluation failure	Dependence on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge	AI-generated outputs receive insufficient evaluation, verification, and oversight	Knowledge verification progressively weakens	Knowledge validation erosion
Knowledge validation erosion	Persistent evaluation failure	Reliable knowledge becomes increasingly difficult to validate, integrate, and renew	Organizational KG capability deteriorates	KGF
KGF	Progressive deterioration of knowledge validation capability	Governance mechanisms become increasingly ineffective in sustaining reliable organizational knowledge	Reliable knowledge creation, transfer, and renewal can no longer be sustained	Organizational brain rot
Organizational brain rot	Persistent KGF	Human expertise, tacit knowledge, and organizational learning progressively deteriorate	Capability renewal and organizational adaptation become increasingly difficult	Organizational knowledge deterioration
Organizational knowledge deterioration	Persistent organizational brain rot	Capability gaps become increasingly difficult to recognize and correct	Continued dependence on symbolic AI positioning reinforces governance deterioration	Continued AI washing (self-reinforcing cycle)

Source(s): Authors' own work

expertise, contextual judgment and substantive knowledge development (Kosmyna *et al.*, 2025). Employees and managers may therefore prioritize externally visible forms of technological sophistication over careful analysis, experiential learning and critical evaluation. These incentive distortions may contribute to a crowding-out effect in which weakly validated AI-generated outputs gradually displace human expertise, domain-specific knowledge, and reflective organizational learning processes (March, 1991).

These dynamics may weaken important dimensions of the SECI model of knowledge creation, particularly the socialization and internalization stages that rely on mentorship, peer interaction, experiential learning and tacit knowledge transfer. As employees increasingly bypass collaborative learning in favor of readily accessible AI-generated outputs, opportunities to develop contextual understanding and domain-specific expertise may decline. Persistent symbolic AI adoption may therefore weaken the organization's capacity to preserve, transfer and integrate tacit knowledge across individuals, teams and organizational routines (Grant, 1996; Nonaka, 1994). As tacit knowledge erodes, firms' knowledge resource base becomes depleted, limiting their ability to renew, recombine and develop organizational capabilities, consistent with the KBV.

Persistent dependence on weakly validated AI-generated outputs may reduce employees' willingness to engage in independent interpretation, critical reflection and experiential learning. As human expertise and tacit knowledge transfer decline, organizations become less capable of creating, transferring and renewing reliable knowledge across individuals, teams and organizational routines (Grant, 1996; Nonaka, 1994). From a KG perspective, these changes weaken the organizational processes required to sustain reliable knowledge creation, knowledge transfer and capability renewal (Gerlach and Lange, 2026). Consequently, organizational learning capacity may decline as employees and managers become increasingly reliant on AI-generated responses while engaging less frequently in independent interpretation (Kosmyna *et al.*, 2025), critical reflection, and substantive knowledge verification, creating the conditions under which evaluation failure subsequently emerges.

4.3 Evaluation failure and knowledge validation erosion

As organizational learning capability deteriorates, organizations become less capable of critically evaluating AI-generated outputs before operational use. Evaluation failure emerges as AI-generated outputs receive insufficient evaluation, verification and governance oversight (Storey, 2026). It refers to organizations' increasing reliance on AI-generated outputs without adequately assessing their reliability, contextual appropriateness or operational limitations. As weakly validated assumptions accumulate, AI-generated knowledge becomes incorporated into organizational databases, standard operating procedures (SOPs), training materials and routine decision-making processes (Liu and Li, 2026; Nelson and Winter, 2004). Consequently, organizations become less able to distinguish reliable technological knowledge from weakly validated AI-generated outputs, reducing the effectiveness of knowledge verification and governance.

Persistent evaluation failure contributes to knowledge validation erosion, defined as the deterioration of the organization's capability to evaluate, validate, integrate and preserve reliable technological knowledge. As validation mechanisms weaken, organizations become less capable of detecting accumulated errors, correcting ineffective technological practices, and maintaining reliable knowledge standards across organizational routines (Gerlach and Lange, 2026). These governance deficiencies may weaken multiple dimensions of organizational intellectual capital. Structural capital becomes increasingly dependent on unreliable data, routines and technological assumptions embedded within organizational systems. Human capital weakens as employees become increasingly dependent on AI-generated interpretations rather than independent judgment and experiential learning, while relational capital may deteriorate when external stakeholders recognize inconsistencies between symbolic AI narratives and actual organizational capability development.

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The institutionalization of weakly validated AI-generated knowledge further weakens organizational knowledge validation capability, reducing the organization's capacity to sustain reliable knowledge creation, validation, integration, transfer and renewal. Consequently, knowledge validation erosion culminates in KGF, where governance mechanisms become incapable of sustaining reliable organizational knowledge. This deterioration leaves organizations vulnerable to long-term declines in organizational learning and capability development, creating the conditions for organizational brain rot.

4.4 Reinforcing dynamics of the knowledge governance failure process

Taken together, Figure 2 conceptualizes AI washing as a sequential KGF process rather than a collection of independent organizational mechanisms. Each stage creates the conditions for the next, culminating in a self-reinforcing feedback loop through which organizational knowledge deterioration perpetuates AI washing.

Persistent symbolic AI adoption redirects managerial attention and organizational resources away from substantive capability development, resulting in resource misallocation, cognitive decoupling and cognitive debt accumulation (Ocasio, 1997; Branda, 2026; Sun *et al.*, 2026). As cognitive debt accumulates, organizations become increasingly dependent on weakly validated AI-generated knowledge that receives insufficient evaluation and verification (Guillen-Aguinaga *et al.*, 2025). Evaluation failure reduces the organization's ability to distinguish reliable knowledge from weakly validated information, allowing unreliable knowledge to become embedded within organizational databases, standard operating procedures, and routine decision-making processes (Nelson and Winter, 2004). As a result, governance mechanisms become less capable of validating, integrating and renewing reliable organizational knowledge.

KGF represents the critical transition point in this process. As governance capability deteriorates, organizations become unable to sustain reliable knowledge creation, validation, integration, transfer and renewal. Organizational learning capability consequently weakens, contributing to organizational brain rot through the deterioration of human expertise, contextual judgment and organizational cognitive resilience (Grant, 1996; Nonaka, 1994; Kosmyna *et al.*, 2025). These cumulative changes ultimately reduce organizational knowledge quality, reliability and capability renewal.

The reinforcing feedback loop in Figure 2 suggests that deteriorating organizational knowledge systems reduce organizations' ability to recognize and correct capability gaps. Organizations therefore become more likely to rely on symbolic AI positioning rather than substantive capability development, reinforcing AI washing and initiating a new cycle of the KGF process.

5. Implications

Overall, this article makes several contributions. Theoretically, this study integrates the KBV and KGT by conceptualizing AI washing as a nascent yet insufficiently theorized form of symbolic AI adoption in organizations. Moving beyond existing discussions that primarily characterize AI washing as the overstatement or inflation of AI use, we contend that persistent symbolic AI adoption represents a dynamic knowledge governance failure process. Specifically, it progressively weakens organizational learning, distorts managerial attention and resource allocation, and diminishes the organization's capacity to validate, integrate and leverage reliable knowledge for sustained capability development.

In terms of practical implications, our illustrative case analysis suggests that the risks of AI washing extend beyond symbolic AI adoption and may progressively undermine organizational learning, knowledge validation and knowledge governance. Under legitimacy and competitive pressures, managers may prioritize visible AI initiatives over the

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development of substantive AI capabilities and governance mechanisms (Bennich, 2024; Branda, 2026). Accordingly, organizations should address AI washing as a knowledge governance challenge rather than merely a disclosure or reputational issue.

Addressing AI washing requires coordinated governance across organizational functions. Executive leaders should align AI-related communication with genuine investments in AI capabilities, organizational learning and knowledge infrastructure while ensuring consistency between AI strategy and internally validated organizational capabilities (Ocasio, 1997; Chaddad, 2026; Shi *et al.*, 2025). Knowledge governance managers should establish robust processes to verify the reliability, traceability and contextual appropriateness of AI-generated knowledge before operational integration (Foss, 2007; Nelson and Winter, 2004). At the organizational level, HR, learning and operational managers should strengthen AI literacy, absorptive capacity, tacit knowledge transfer and oversight of AI-assisted decisions (Grant, 1996; Nonaka, 1994). Regular governance reviews and knowledge verification can help organizations detect early signs of strategic decoupling and knowledge governance failure before unreliable AI-generated knowledge becomes embedded in organizational routines (Guillen-Aguinaga *et al.*, 2025).

6. Conclusion

This article reconceptualizes AI washing as a KGF rather than merely a symbolic or reputational phenomenon. By integrating the KBV and KGT, we argue that persistent symbolic AI adoption may create strategic decoupling between external AI narratives and internal organizational capabilities, gradually weakening organizational learning, knowledge validation and capability development.

The proposed framework conceptualizes AI washing as a sequential governance failure process in which symbolic AI adoption contributes to cognitive debt accumulation, knowledge governance failure and ultimately organizational brain rot. In doing so, the study extends existing discussions of AI washing beyond disclosure and legitimacy concerns to explain how persistent symbolic AI adoption may progressively erode the governance processes required to create, validate, integrate and renew reliable organizational knowledge.

As a conceptual study, the proposed framework requires empirical validation. Future research should examine the proposed mechanisms across different organizational and institutional contexts and identify governance practices that can interrupt the progression from symbolic AI adoption to knowledge governance failure. Ultimately, the value of AI depends not on how prominently organizations claim to adopt it, but on how effectively they govern and integrate AI-generated knowledge into sustained organizational learning and capability development.

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